

MAPLE GROVE CROSS COUNTRY

TEAM HANDBOOK - 2026



COACHING STAFF	
Hannah Hempe	Program Co-Head Coach, Varsity - hempeh@district279.org (Room 215)
Sean Heaton	Program Co-Head Coach, Varsity - heatons@district279.org (Room 126)
Mike Kuhlman	Assistant Coach, JV
Kenzie Waataja	Assistant Coach, JV
Sydney Hagen	Assistant Coach, JV & Middle School
Lauren Tillman	Assistant Coach, JV & Middle School
Gideon Heroux	Assistant Coach, Middle School
Haleigh Thompson	Assistant Coach, Middle School
Javan Copley	Strength Coach
Lindsey Young	Volunteer Coach

CONFIDENT - COMPETE - COMMUNITY

TEAM PHILOSOPHY

Maple Grove Cross Country's team philosophy centers on three key pillars - **confident, compete, and community**. The "3 C's" drives all of the work of our team. Through the 3 C's, we work to ensure each student-athlete:

- Further develops their **confidence** in & outside of running.
- Learns & demonstrates what it means to be a healthy **competitor**.
- Becomes a part of an uplifting **community**. We do better together.
- Supports the community around them.

By putting into practice our team philosophy, we strive to foster well-rounded athletic and personal development of each-student athlete by nurturing their physical, mental, and emotional growth. Through their participation in Maple Grove Cross Country, each student-athlete will be empowered to reach their highest potential in and outside of running.

TEAM VISION

By first developing a team culture that fosters a strong sense of community and emphasizes being healthy and confident competitors, our vision is that the Maple Grove Cross Country program will be consistently competitive at all levels. This includes being consistently competitive at the conference, section, and state level for the varsity teams. The success of the entire program relies on each individual student-athlete, and the results at each level (varsity, JV, and middle school) are the byproduct of the culture our student-athletes work to build together year after year.

By putting our team philosophy into action, our vision is to ensure that each student-athlete has an experience that they are excited to participate in for the maximum number of years possible, whether it is a junior athlete joining for the first time continuing through their senior year or a seventh grader remaining on the team for six years.

PILLAR #1: CONFIDENT

In order for MGXC athletes to further develop their **confidence** in & outside of running, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Complete training plan provided by MGXC coaching staff with consistency**

One way athletes can develop their confidence as a runner is through completing & trusting their training. Training plans have been developed for runners of different abilities & age levels. This is to help athletes continue their development over the course of their cross country careers. Athletes should collaborate with the MGXC coaching staff to determine which plan is correct for them.

PILLAR #1: CONFIDENT CONTINUED

In order for MGXC athletes to further develop their **confidence** in & outside of running, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Complete training plan provided by MGXC coaching staff with consistency**

Tracking Mileage: High school athletes are expected to fill out the weekly mileage google form to ensure that they are training at the right level. Athletes will receive a verbal warning the first time they do not fill out the weekly mileage form. Upon additional times missing the weekly mileage form, an athlete may be asked to sit out a meet.

Running Standard for MGXC Participation: In order to continue being a member of Maple Grove Cross Country, it is an expectation that all returning 10th - 12th must be able to run 25 minutes continuously by the start of the season (during week 1 & 2 of practice). Although this expectation does not apply to incoming 7th - 9th grade runners and new upperclassmen, it is a helpful benchmark to use to ensure your athlete is ready for the training load of cross country. This expectation is being implemented to ensure the safety and progress of our MGXC athletes.

Multi-Sport Athletes: There are many benefits to being a multi-sport athlete, especially for youth athletes. We understand that many of our cross country athletes are involved in other activities throughout the year and may have practices during the cross country season. If this is the case, it needs to be communicated with the coaching staff to ensure athletes are engaging in the right level of cross country training and not experiencing burnout from overtraining in either sport. We also request that the coaches of the other sport are informed of the athlete participating in the high school cross country team and that cross country is their current in-season, high school sport that should be prioritized.

Multi-sport athletes competing on the MGXC varsity roster will be asked to pause training for all non-cross country sports during the championship portion (conference, sections, state) of the season. Taking this step, allows athletes to ensure they are able to compete at their best for their teammates.

Required Equipment for Training: Running shoes, watch, water bottle, lock for locker room, snacks for during school day & before/after practice

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Participate in mental skills training sessions at practice**

The strongest runners spend time training their brain, just like they do their bodies. Throughout the season, athletes are expected to engage in mental skills training sessions. Different strategies will work for different athletes; we believe it is important to take time as a program to introduce different strategies in order to help each athlete find ones that work for them.

PILLAR #1: CONFIDENT CONTINUED

In order for MGXC athletes to further develop their **confidence** in & outside of running, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Compete with confidence**

MGXC coaching staff will determine race lineups in order to ensure each athlete is in the position to race confidently. Athletes should compete with confidence in themselves, their race plan, their goals, & their teammates. Athletes should discuss with the coaches if they are unsure of their race plan.

Varsity Roster Selection Policy: Typically 7 - 12 athletes compete in a varsity race. The coaching staff will select varsity spots based on results from the entirety of the current season, while prioritizing the most recent results over older results. Athlete conduct is also a factor determining in varsity spots (ex: practice attendance).

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Uplift teammates & yourself by engaging in body-positive talk**

Every body type can run. In order to create a healthy, confident environment for each athlete, we ask that every member of the program (athletes, parents/guardians, coaches, etc) engage in body-positive talk and refrain from talking negatively about their body or other's bodies. A later section of the handbook will discuss the importance of athletic nutrition.

PILLAR #2: COMPETE

In order for MGXC athletes to learn & practice what it means to be a healthy **competitor**, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Strive to have balance as a student-athlete**

As a coaching staff, we believe that athlete mental and physical well-being always needs to be priority #1. There are a lot of demands placed on student-athletes. It is important that athletes find a way to balance these demands to ensure that they are working on having positive mental and physical health. If you are struggling to find balance, it is important to reach out to a trusted adult (parent/guardian, coach, school counselor, etc).

MGSH Counseling: <https://sites.google.com/apps.district279.org/maple-grove-senior-counseling/home>

OMS Counseling: <https://oms.district279.org/services/counseling>

MGMS Counseling: <https://mgms.district279.org/services/counseling>

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Do the little things right**

The MGXC coaching staff have developed routines for injury prevention. They may seem like a "little thing" at practice but these routines are essential in ensuring that each athlete can compete healthy for the duration of the season and beyond. Athletes are expected to participate in these routines. These routines include: warm-ups, cool-downs, strides, hip mobility, band walks, med balls, hurdles, & weight room strength.

Weight Room Opportunities: Strength training designed for MGXC by Coach Javan (only available to high school athletes). Wednesdays 6:00am, Saturdays 9:30am. Athletes seeking to participate at the varsity-level are expected to complete the MGXC strength training program.

PILLAR #2: COMPETE CONTINUED

In order for MGXC athletes to learn & practice what it means to be a healthy **competitor**, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Listen to your body**

You know yourself best. It is important that you listen to what your body is telling you to ensure that you are able to be a healthy competitor for the eternity of the xc season and beyond.

Nutrition: It is critical that you fuel yourself to be an athlete. Your body will ask for more food the more active you are. Listen to your body and fuel yourself. Food is important & food is good. There should be no restricting of food. Key considerations to fuel yourself for athletics is to eat well balanced meals with many colors on your plate, snack often, and eat within one hour after hard workouts to help with the recovery process. It is important to remind yourself that everyone will need different fuel - what you see a runner eat on TikTok might not be what is best for you. Listen to your own body & fuel yourself well.

For more info, see [link for Sports Nutrition Info Sheet](#) provided by guest speaker, Katie Reagan (MS, RD). Will need to be logged into @apps.district279 account to access.

Hydration: Staying hydrated is essential for being a healthy competitor. Athletes need to be drinking water throughout the entire day (before, during, and after practice or meets). Each athlete should own a water bottle and carry it with them during the school day and bring it to practice.

Sleep: Sleep is the best tool to prevent injuries and promote positive mental and physical health as student-athletes. It is best to keep a consistent sleep schedule during the week and weekends. Athletes need 8-10 hours of sleep a night.

Injuries: If you think you have an injury, tell your coach immediately and see the trainer (AJ Syler). The trainer's office is located in the athletic hallway. There is no charge to get an evaluation. Results of evaluation should be shared with your coach and parent/guardian.

Iron & Ferritin: Iron is crucial for teen runners because it helps to carry oxygen to muscles and impacts energy levels, bone density, and overall performance. Endurance running can sometimes impact a teen's iron levels. If a parent/guardian is concerned about their athlete's levels, they could ask their primary care physician to check their athlete's ferritin levels. Ferritin is a blood protein that stores iron. Checking ferritin levels gives a clear picture of the body's iron reserves. Tell your physician your athlete's average weekly mileage and/or participation in other sports, as it is important that they understand your athlete is active.

For Female Athletes - Menstrual Health (Periods): Once an athlete has received her first period, it is important that she understands what a regular period is like for her and understands the importance of having a regular period. Having a regular menstrual cycle is crucial for female athletes as it is a key indicator of overall health and hormonal balance. A normal period signifies that the body is receiving adequate nutrition and is not under excessive physical stress. Maintaining menstrual health supports optimal performance, recovery, and long-term well-being. Ignoring menstrual irregularities can lead to serious conditions such as energy deficiency, bone density loss, and an increased risk of injuries. It is essential for female athletes to monitor and prioritize their menstrual health.

PILLAR #2: COMPETE CONTINUED

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Follow all Minnesota State High School League & Maple Grove Senior High policies.**

MSHSL Academic Standing Policy: In order to compete in meets, athletes must be in good academic standing and on track to graduate. Engaging in behavior that is considered academic dishonesty can result in not competing in a meet per MSHSL & MGSHP policies. Violations will be handled according to MSHSL and MGSHP/district policy.

MSHSL Chemical Policy: By joining the cross country team, athletes are agreeing to follow the chemical free rules outlined by Maple Grove Senior High School and the Minnesota State High School League. Violations will be handled according to MSHSL and MGSHP/district policy.

MSHSL Harassment & Hazing Prevention Policy: Our cross country team strives to have an inclusive environment for each athlete. By joining the cross country team, athletes are agreeing to follow the harassment and hazing prevention policies of Maple Grove Senior High and the Minnesota State High School League. Violations will be handled according to MSHSL and MGSHP/district policy.

The above MSHSL & MGSHP policies extend to the locker room, social media usage, & the school day.

PILLAR #3: COMMUNITY

In order for MGXC athletes to become a part of an uplifting **community**, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Support your teammates, have confidence in your teammates**

We all do better when we work together. There will be many opportunities for athletes to develop community with their team throughout the season. Team building events are just as important as practice -- athletes should do their best to attend all team building opportunities.

It is essential that you are supportive, respectful and welcoming of your teammates. This will help further the confidence of each member of Maple Grove Cross Country. Have confidence that your teammates are putting in the work needed for the success of the entire team.

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Attend practice daily**

The practice schedule is available on SafeTeam. Athletes are required to attend the entirety of practice each day. Work and appointments should be scheduled around the cross country practice and meet schedule. Excused absences must be communicated with COACH HEATON IN-PERSON prior to the absence, unless due to illness the absence can be communicated via email. Excused absences include illness, doctor's appointment, major family events, and required school events that cannot be scheduled at an alternate time.

College visits will only be counted as an excused absence once during the cross country season - schedule your college visits around our practice and competition schedule.

Other sport practices and/or try-outs are not considered excused absences. Athletes are expected to attend MGXC practice during OMGHA & OMGBA try out week. Athletes should communicate with MGXC coaching staff during their try out week as their cross country training can be adapted slightly.

Academic Support: If a high school athlete needs to get help from a teacher, they should try their best to schedule a time with the teacher during Crimson Hour, before school, or after school prior to practice. Being a student comes first in student-athlete. If you need to schedule academic support during practice, please communicate with the coaches to determine which day is best and then join practice at the start of the middle school session.

PILLAR #3: COMMUNITY CONTINUED

In order for MGXC athletes to become a part of an uplifting **community**, athletes are expected to:

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Attend practice daily**

Multiple unexcused absences will be handled by the following actions:

- *1st Unexcused Absence:* Coaches will talk with the athlete.
- *2nd Unexcused Absence:* Coaches have the right to withhold participation from a meet.
- *3 or More Unexcused Absences:* Can result in the removal from the team based on coaches' judgment.

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Take the bus to and from cross country meets**

When buses are provided, athletes are expected to take the bus to and from cross country meets. This further develops a strong team community through supporting your teammates in each race. Athletes may be excused from riding the bus home only due to a school-sponsored event (i.e. band concert).

- **TEAM EXPECTATION: Be a positive member of the greater Maple Grove community**

As a cross country team, we are often practicing within the Maple Grove community. Athletes are expected to be respectful of private property while on runs, share space on public trails, and use respectful language. Represent MGXC well!

In addition, the culture we hope to build amongst the Maple Grove Cross Country team extends to the classroom. We expect athletes to be known as positive role models by their teachers and classmates.

Behavior concerns will be handled by coaches and follow MGSH/MSHSL policies, which may result in missing a meet.

ADDITIONAL TEAM POLICIES

LETTERING POLICY: To receive a letter, athletes must receive 10 lettering points. Athletes will fill out the lettering worksheet at the end of the season and turn it in to COACH HEMPE. [The lettering worksheet is linked HERE.](#)

COMMUNICATION: Communication with coaches should be done via email, in-person before or at the end of practice / meets, or a private chat on Safe Team. Coaches will respond to messages within the work week/hours (Mon - Fri) and will do their best to respond within 24 hours.

ADDITIONAL TEAM POLICIES CONT.

PARENT/GUARDIAN SUPPORT: We ask that parents/guardians are their athletes' biggest cheerleader. Let the coaching be done by the MGXC coaching staff. Your athlete will need your support and positive encouragement throughout the highs and lows that come with sports participation.

On meet day, we request that family & friends coming to watch MGXC runners make plans to meet up with their athlete based on team warm-up and cool-down times. Athletes are expected to warm-up with their team an hour prior to the start of their race and cool-down with their team at the end of their race. During the warm-up & cool-down times, athletes need to be with their team and we request that spectators are not in the team tent & warm-up area.

GENERAL INFORMATION

SAFE TEAM: All information (schedules, weekly communication, team building opportunities, etc) can be found on SafeTeam. You can either download SafeTeam from the app store or use the web browser version. To join the Maple Grove Cross Country page, you will need to scan a QR code provided by MGXC coaching staff.

PRACTICE TRANSPORTATION:

- *Middle School Athletes TO Practice:* Activity buses leave the middle schools at 2:50 PM each day and will drop you off at MGS. The bus leaves MGMS (route 270 and 276) from the front side of the building facing Hemlock. OMS (route 374) leaves on the east side of the building, facing OSH.
- *Late Bus AFTER Practice:* A late bus is available only Tuesday-Thursday. Buses leave the high school at 4:45 PM. The routes will be different from the athlete's normal school route. A list of routes and stops will be posted in the cafeteria by door D. The main office receives a report of students that are assigned to late activity buses each week.

*** This is the bus information from last year. If the bus information changes for 2025, we will post an update on HelloTeam/Safe Team.*

EQUIPMENT:

- Good pair of running shoes (new shoes needed every 300 - 500 miles)
- Watch
- Water bottle
- Snacks (for during school day, before, & after practice)
- Lock (for locker in locker room)
- Spikes (commonly purchased, not required)
- Basic black shorts &/or spandex (commonly purchased, not required)